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is starting to come up but in India it still has some way to go. Currently, in India, the easy thing for anyone to do is the conventional solar installation,” she says.

No house can be truly sustainable if you are not conserving water. Use fixtures like dual-flush toilets that allow you to select a lesser or greater flush rate depending on your needs. “A conventional flush tank uses about 9-10 litres of water but dual flush tanks use 6 litres and 3 litres. Now there are 4-litre and 2-litre flushes as well,” says Mohanram. All of your plumbing equipment, including faucets and shower heads, can be set to use less water. Mohanram suggests installing aerators to reduce the water flow. “While a regular tap releases around 15 litres of water a minute at full flow, an aerator can bring it down to 2 litres a minute,” she says.

Next is to treat the wastewater. You need to separate the grey water from the black water. Black water is the toilet flush water while grey water is the

bathing, kitchen and sink water. Both of these can be reused for landscaping once they have been treated. “The idea is to not let the wastewater out of your home. Treat it and reuse it,” advises Mohanram.

Rainwater harvesting is also, of course, important. Save all the rainwater, filter it and then use it.

Unfortunately, if you are moving into a constructed apartment, there isn’t much you can do except use energy-efficient equipment and eco-friendly material for the interiors. Avneet Kaur, Livpreneur at interior design firm Livspace, suggests using repurposed wood, bamboo and wicker for cabinets, along with eco-friendly wallpaper since paints are harmful. “You can get your windows double glazed and use solar window panels,” she suggests.

Of course, step one to being sustainable is to not build a house at all, but if you are building one, make it a sustainable one. **BT**

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